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WORKING CONDITIONS AND WORKER RESPONSES ON NYASALAND TEA ESTATES, 1930–1953

BY ROBIN PALMER

Labour in Nyasaland is in many ways very similar to the climate.
It is erratic, unpredictable, and at times highly frustrating.

Nyasaland tea planter, 1962¹

A PREVIOUS article² examined the emergence and development of Nyasaland's tea industry during the 1930s and 1940s under the protection of the International Tea Regulation Scheme. It was argued that tea regulations were largely responsible for raising world tea prices. This in turn permitted Nyasaland's low quality teas, produced under unfavourable growing conditions, to be marketed profitably. Some tea planters were thus able to enjoy a modest prosperity at a time when other white farmers in the country were being driven off the land or into sharecropping.³ This article will concentrate on 'the other side of the coin' – on working conditions on the tea estates and on workers' varied responses to those conditions. Nyasaland's tea workers have sometimes been depicted as little more than helpless slaves, and whilst this may possibly be true for certain periods in time, it will be argued that the reality between 1930 and 1953 was more complex and that some workers at least were able to exploit options which kept the planters at bay and which resulted in millions of pounds of tea going unpicked.

LAND AND LABOUR

It was the tobacco collapse of 1928 which provided the impetus for the real emergence of the tea industry in the Cholo (now Thyolo) and Mlanje (now Mulanje) districts of southern Nyasaland (now Malawi). In the Shire Highlands, of which these districts form a part, almost a million acres had been ceded by chiefs to white settlers in the 1880s prior to colonial occupation. Most of these grants were subsequently ratified by Harry Johnston, the first colonial administrator.⁴ One consequence was that com-

¹ 'Planter', 'Comments on climatic, agricultural and labour conditions in Nyasaland', in Wilson, Smithett & Co., *Tea Estates in Africa* (London, 1962), 24. The archival sources used here are the Public Record Office, London (files prefixed C.O.), the National Archives of Malawi, Zomba (various prefixes) and, thanks to the generosity of Landeg White, the archives of Blantyre and East Africa Ltd, Lauderdale Estate, Mulanje, Malawi. I have also used the evidence to the Hilton Young, Bledisloe and Land Commissions, which is to be found in the Foreign and Commonwealth Office Library, London. I am grateful to Barbara Morrow for locating some material in Zomba subsequent to my departure from Malawi and to John McCracken, Forbes Munro, Leroy Vail, Megan Vaughan and Landeg White for their comments on an earlier version of this article.

² Robin Palmer, 'The Nyasaland tea industry in the era of international tea restrictions, 1933–1950', *J. Afr. Hist.*, xxvi (1985), 215–39.

³ Robin Palmer, 'White farmers in Malawi: before and after the Depression', *African Affairs*, LXXXIV (1985), 211–45.

⁴ Roland Oliver, *Sir Harry Johnston and the Scramble for Africa* (London, 1957), 197–244; B. S. Krishnamurthy, 'Land and labour in Nyasaland, 1891–1914' (Ph.D.

panies such as Blantyre and East Africa Ltd, the British Central Africa Co. Ltd, A. L. Bruce Estates Ltd. and the African Lakes Corporation Ltd. came to possess tracts of land which were vastly greater than they could productively use.⁵ A second was that patterns of black settlement on white-owned land were extremely complex. The dense Mang'anja populations of the mid-nineteenth century were swept aside by Yao, Ngoni and slave raiders, and when land was sold to whites in the 1880s much of it, like the 'White Highlands' of Kenya, was unoccupied at the time. Thereafter, as Landeg White has pointed out, the key issue 'was not the terms on which Africans could be driven from their ancestral lands but the terms on which they would be permitted to settle'.⁶ Throughout southern Africa control over labour was of paramount concern to white farmers. For those in southern Nyasaland, what might otherwise have proved an intractable problem was to some degree resolved by official pressures and brutalities in neighbouring Portuguese East Africa, which led to a massive immigration into the Shire Highlands of people first described as 'Anguru', who later called themselves Lomwe. An estimated 100,000 had entered Nyasaland by 1920; in Mlanje, which was on the Portuguese border, they had 'penetrated to all parts of the district' by 1931,⁷ while by 1945 the Lomwe population was said to number 380,000.⁸ Such a massive repopulation of the Shire Highlands can be compared to the nineteenth century colonization of central Tanzania.⁹

White landowners (as well as Yao and Mang'anja chiefs) obviously welcomed this influx of Lomwe. Indeed they quite deliberately and consciously sought to attract them by offering them land (of which they had an abundance) in return for labour (of which they were in dire need). A system

thesis, University of London, 1964); Eric Stokes, 'Malawi political systems and the introduction of colonial rule, 1891-1896', in Eric Stokes and Richard Brown (eds.), *The Zambesian Past* (Manchester, 1966), 352-75; Robin Palmer, 'Johnston and Jameson: a comparative study in the imposition of colonial rule', in Bridglal Pachai (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi* (London, 1971), 293-322; B. S. Krishnamurthy, 'Economic policy, land and labour in Nyasaland, 1890-1914', in Pachai, *Early History*, 384-404; Simon S. Myambo, 'The Shire Highlands plantations: a socio-economic history of the plantation system of production in Malawi, 1891-1938' (M.A. thesis, University of Malawi, 1973); Bridglal Pachai, 'Land policies in Malawi: an examination of the colonial legacy', *J. Afr. Hist.*, xiv (1973), 681-98; Bridglal Pachai, *Land and politics in Malawi, 1875-1975* (Kingston, Ontario, 1978).

⁵ C.O. 525/208/44332/3, 'History of the British Central Africa Company', 1948, and 'History of the Blantyre and East Africa Company', 1949. By 1949 Governor Colby was of the opinion that 'the fact that the British Central Africa Company has held vast areas of land in this territory for fifty years or more, for which the Company paid little or nothing, has been one of the major factors in retarding the development of Nyasaland': *ibid.*, Colby to Creech Jones, 15 March 1949.

⁶ Landeg White, '"Tribes" and the aftermath of the Chilembwe rising', *African Affairs*, LXXXIII (1984), 516.

⁷ L. H. L. Foster, 'The human geography of the Mlanje district, Nyasaland', *Geography*, xvi (1931), 266.

⁸ C. Baker, 'A note on Nguru immigration to Nyasaland', *Nyasaland Journal*, xiv (1961), 42. See also Alifeyo Chilivumbo, 'On labour and Alomwe immigration', *Rural Africana*, xxiv (1974), 49-57; Thomas Galligan, 'The Nguru penetration into Nyasaland, 1892-1914', in Roderick J. Macdonald (ed.), *From Nyasaland to Malawi* (Nairobi, 1975), 108-23; H. H. K. Bhila, 'The role of the Ngoni and the Lomwe in the growth of the plantation economy of the Shire Highlands, 1890-1912', *Journal of Social Science*, v (1976), 28-43; R. B. Boeder, *Silent majority: a History of the Lomwe in Malawi* (Pretoria, 1984).

⁹ John Iliffe, *A Modern History of Tanganyika* (Cambridge, 1979), 4-14, 74-6.

of labour rent, known locally as *thangata*,¹⁰ became established under which tenants were normally required to work one month to pay off their tax and another to pay their rent – both during the crucial rainy season. *Thangata* agreements were made verbally and ‘one month’ proved in practice to be a somewhat elastic concept. The commission investigating the Chilembwe Rising of 1915 supplied (rather against its will, one suspects) ample evidence of the abuses to which the system had given rise.¹¹ The government, recognizing the danger of future unrest, sought to offer tenants some protection, but landlords moved quickly to ignore or emasculate such ordinances as found their way onto the statute book.¹² On the eve of the development of the tea industry a compromise of sorts had been reached in the 1928 Natives on Private Estates Ordinance. This was a complex law, much amended in the drafting,¹³ whose implementation tended to confuse administrators, landlords and tenants alike. It stipulated that written agreements, witnessed by district commissioners, had to offer tenants the choice of paying rent either in cash or in labour, and if labour was not required (as often proved to be the case in the depressed 1930s), then a share of the tenant’s crop, on land made available by the landlord, was to be offered in lieu. Landlords were to be permitted to evict up to a maximum of 10 per cent of their tenantry at the end of each quinquennial period, starting in 1933. The Ordinance survived uneasily into the 1950s, but *thangata* continued to be bitterly disliked and was at the root of much tension. The tea industry emerged, therefore, in a context of long standing conflict between landlord and tenant.

In time the Lomwe came to provide the bulk of the labour force on the tea estates. They were vulnerable, like all immigrants. Initially they were beholden either to planter or chief for access to land. Those who settled under chiefs on crown land, which constituted the least productive half of the Shire Highlands, had to work clearing land and later growing crops in return for food in their first year. Subsequently they sought the best terms they could find, and they very soon entertained visions of upward mobility.¹⁴ As White

¹⁰ J. A. Kamchitete Kandawire, *Thangata: Forced Labour or Reciprocal Assistance?* (Zomba, 1979); B. Pachai, ‘The issue of *thangata* in the history of Nyasaland’, *Journal of Social Science*, III (1974), 20–34.

¹¹ Nyasaland Protectorate, *Report of the Commission appointed by His Excellency the Governor to Inquire into Various Matters and Questions Concerned with the Native Rising within the Nyasaland Protectorate* (Zomba, 1916).

¹² The government was particularly concerned to protect tenants from eviction. Harry Johnston’s ‘non-disturbance clause’ theoretically offered protection to tenants resident on estates at the time (1892–5) when he ratified the settlers’ land claims. Shifting cultivation and Lomwe immigration combined to obscure the issue and ensure that vast amounts of time and energy were devoted to determining who was, and who was not, entitled to protection under Johnston’s clause.

¹³ Palmer, ‘White farmers’, 217–18.

¹⁴ Official ideology asserted that the Lomwe ‘are welcomed by the planting community for they are industrious as temporary resident workers on an estate, and they are preferred in this capacity to the indigenous native, who is liable to allow himself to be too much distracted by his home and family ties to exhibit that concentration of effort which is a desirable attribute even in the unskilled labourer. Unfortunately, the Nguru does not content himself with entering the Protectorate for the purpose of seeking temporary employment; in increasing numbers he is settling both on Crown and on privately owned land, and as soon as he finds himself comfortably established with a place in the village community he also begins to find his distractions to be an obstacle to the continuance of

has noted, chiefs and aspirant chiefs competed for followers in an endeavour to boost their frequently spurious claims to authority.¹⁵ This situation offered the Lomwe some flexibility and resulted in constant movement between districts, estates and Crown Land. Generally though, and in contrast to local Nyasas, they were unable to migrate to better paid employment in Southern Rhodesia or South Africa for fear that their families might be deprived of access to land. They were thus trapped in a vice of varying degrees of tightness, and Leroy Vail is surely correct to insist that, *au fond*, the viability of the plantation sector in colonial Malawi rested on the ability to tap and exploit cheap Lomwe labour.¹⁶

THE COMPOSITION OF THE LABOUR FORCE

The tea estates in Nyasaland, as elsewhere in the world, were highly labour-intensive. Disappointing results were obtained from occasional attempts to increase mechanization, which were invariably undertaken at times of acute labour shortage. The total labour force employed in the peak season rose from some twenty thousand at the end of the 1930s to around thirty thousand by the early 1950s. This last figure was ten thousand short of stated requirements. As with all agricultural undertakings the demand for labour fluctuated seasonally, with the peak period coming from December to April during the rains when the bulk of the tea was plucked and manufactured. A variety of tasks were performed on tea estates, ranging from hoeing, weeding and pruning, which were paid least, through plucking, factory work and overseeing to clerical work, which fetched the highest wages. Managerial posts at this time were held exclusively by whites.

In 1941 it was estimated that 47 per cent of workers on tea estates came from local villages in Cholo and Mlanje, including 3 per cent who were estate tenants, whilst 27 per cent came from other districts in Nyasaland and a further 25 per cent were seasonal migrants from Portuguese East Africa.¹⁷ Labour Department statistics for the period 1954 to 1959 suggest that such proportions may also have obtained, approximately, for those years.¹⁸ Such his former industry.' Nyasaland Protectorate, *Report on Native Affairs for the Year Ended 31st December, 1932* (Zomba, 1933), 5.

¹⁵ White, 'Tribes', 519. See also Alfred V. Ntonga, 'The Lomwe of Chief Nkanda: their intrusion into and adaptation to the Malawian environment', University of Malawi, Chancellor College History seminar paper (1985).

¹⁶ Leroy Vail, 'The state and the creation of colonial Malawi's agricultural economy', in Robert I. Rotberg (ed.), *Imperialism, Colonialism, and Hunger: East and Central Africa* (Lexington, 1983), 50-1.

¹⁷ Nyasaland Protectorate, *Annual Report of the Labour Department of the Provincial Administration for the Year Ending 31st December, 1941* (Zomba, 1942), 3.

¹⁸ Origins of adult male employees in the tea industry, 31 March (source: Labour Department Annual Reports, 1954-9):

	Southern Province	Central and Northern Provinces	Portuguese East Africa	Other	Total
1954	23,776	2,444	4,850	22	31,092
1955	20,921	272	7,281	4	28,478
1956	27,965	1,367	7,038	7	36,377
1957	21,845	1,127	6,373	19	29,364
1958	23,408	880	5,052	46	29,386
1959	20,229	542	5,145	5	25,921

rounded figures mask, however, the fact that the bulk of the local and 'Portuguese' labour went to the Mlanje estates, whilst Cholo was more reliant on 'upcountry' labour recruited through private agreements with chiefs. Of the 31,803 people working on the estates on 31 March 1953, 25,049 (78 per cent) were adult males, 6,435 (20 per cent) were 'young persons' under the age of eighteen, and only 319 (1 per cent) were women.¹⁹ A year earlier, of the 28,668 adult males at work, 25,416 (88 per cent) were classified as labourers, 1,917 (7 per cent) as clerks and 1,335 (5 per cent) as factory workers.²⁰

A 'ticket system' prevailed on the tea estates whereby workers were paid not by the month, but on completion of twenty-six working days (thirty days after 1944). Legally a 'ticket' had to be completed within seven weeks, but in practice many non-tenant workers with obligations elsewhere took three months or even longer to do so. It was widely acknowledged that the labour force 'comes and goes when it likes',²¹ with workers being 'very prone to take a day off whenever the spirit, or a beer-drink, moves them'.²² As far as the Nyasaland Government was concerned, 'the system has the advantage of enabling the native to live his home life and it does not involve long separation from his own domestic interests'.²³ That was of course in contrast to those who migrated to South Africa or Southern Rhodesia. In those countries too the working day on a farm was much longer than in Nyasaland, where a daily 'task' was set, rather than a specific number of hours worked. Most workers in Nyasaland worked for only five to six hours, finishing at noon. They could then return to their neighbouring villages and, especially during the crucial months December to February, attend to food production in their own gardens. This

suits the local labourer and it suits many planters as it enables them to employ natives who would otherwise not be available for work on the plantations; without it the labour shortage at the most critical time of the year would be greatly accentuated.²⁴

However, from the planter's point of view, it was also a somewhat wasteful system, with absenteeism running at between 30 and 40 per cent and the number appearing for work each morning not known in advance. Planters therefore felt obliged to sign onto their labour rolls a far greater number of workers than they actually needed. Thus Malcolm Barrow, Chairman of the Nyasaland Tea Association, required only 1,250 workers on his Cholo estate, Naming'omba, where he had a thousand acres under tea, but he had nearly three thousand names on his roll in 1938.²⁵ Planters lamented the wastefulness

¹⁹ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ending 31st December, 1953* (Zomba, 1954), 11.

²⁰ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ending 31st December, 1952* (Zomba, 1953), 18.

²¹ *Labour Department Annual Report 1941*, 4.

²² *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ended 31st December, 1950* (Zomba, 1951), 4.

²³ *Annual Report of the Labour Branch of the Provincial Administration for the Year Ending 31st December, 1938* (Zomba, 1939), 12.

²⁴ *Labour Department Annual Report, 1941*, 3.

²⁵ Foreign and Commonwealth Office Library, Rhodesia-Nyasaland Royal Commission, Oral Evidence, Volume III: Nyasaland, Evidence of M. P. Barrow, 25 June 1938, 1035. [Henceforth Bledisloe Commission, Evidence.]

of a system which 'locked up' labour in this way, depriving other employers of access to it, but could see no solution to the problem. By the early 1950s a number of them were offering attendance bonuses in an attempt to encourage a more regular turnout.

Tea estates were obliged to provide housing for those workers who were unable to return home at the end of a day's work. The quality varied very greatly and housing played an important role in the post-war scramble for labour. Planters were also obliged to supply food rations or cash in lieu, known as *posho*, to their workers, but not to the wives of male workers.²⁶ The tendency was for workers almost invariably to take cash during the dry season, while some took food during the rains if their own supplies were low or if prices were high in local markets.²⁷ Overtime or 'overtask' work was rarely performed, largely because it was paid only at piecework rates, but complex bonus schemes were offered to pluckers in an attempt to enhance production.²⁸

Six broad categories of workers can be distinguished. By far the largest proportion, almost half in 1941, came from villages on crown land adjoining the tea estates. This was particularly the case in Mlanje, but less so in Cholo, where two-thirds of the district was in white ownership including practically all the better watered upland area. Such local workers clearly enjoyed the greatest flexibility, unambiguous locals more so than immigrant Lomwe. The second group were those who came from other parts of Nyasaland, predominantly from the Central Province. Most of them went to Cholo²⁹ where their compounds bore the names of their home areas. They were procured through agreements made between individual planters and chiefs, who 'would get adequate numbers of workers and send them down to the estates'.³⁰ Little is known about this system, other than that the chiefs received gifts and such workers stayed far longer on the job than local people. Third and most vulnerable were the resident tenants on the estates, predominantly Lomwe. In contrast to the tobacco industry, where half the labour force came from tenants, on the tea estates they comprised a small fraction only. Virtually all were in Cholo, where the dearth of crown land

²⁶ Workers interviewed in 1941 raised the issue of *posho* for wives. This provoked from the Blantyre and East Africa's General Manager in Edinburgh the response that 'Whilst we are all here very anxious to improve labour relations, if that is possible, there is a limit and to our mind the Labour Commissioner is carrying matters much too far, especially if the companies are now to be asked not only to feed the worker himself but also his wife and family'. Blantyre and East Africa Archives, Lauderdale Estate, Mlanje, Tait Bowie papers, Report by Chief Mwase of tour of Mlanje and Cholo tea estates, 6 and 7 Oct. 1941; *ibid.*, Head Office file 1941-3, Stark to Tait Bowie, 9 Dec. 1941.

²⁷ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ending 31st December, 1944* (Zomba, 1945), 3.

²⁸ On the three Blantyre and East Africa estates in Mlanje, Lauderdale, Glenorchy and Limbuli, pluckers were paid a basic wage of 6s. in 1941 plus a bonus of 1d. per 10 lb picked above 35 lb, with Lauderdale offering a graduated scale, 'so that the more plucked the bigger the bonus': BEA Archives, Tait Bowie papers, Leslie to Tait Bowie, 4 March 1941.

²⁹ In 1939 the D.C., Cholo, reported that 60 per cent of the labour on the tea estates came from outside the district: National Archives of Malawi, NSE 5/1/6, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for the year 1939.

³⁰ Patrick D. Lindeirey, 'The tea industry in southern Malawi: its introduction, growth and contribution to the exports of the country up to independence in 1964', University of Malawi, Chancellor College History seminar paper (1985), 18.

coupled with the tenants' inability 'to earn a livelihood from the soil'³¹ made it possible for planters to demand *thangata* during the rainy season. Land shortage, population pressure, grievances over *thangata* and gratuitous harshness on the part of some landowners combined to make Cholo a highly combustible district. Fourth, totalling about a quarter of the workforce, were the young male Lomwe migrants who came across from Portuguese East Africa into Mlanje as seasonal 'hoeing boys' at the lowest wages on offer. They were known as *chitando* workers after the temporary shelters in which they were housed. Their significance may be gauged by the admission of the Mlanje Planters' Association to the visiting Hilton Young Commission in 1928 that 'At the moment, were it not for the labour coming in from Portuguese Territory, we could not carry on'.³² Similarly in 1934 the veteran Cholo planter Conforzi warned the government that since 'the planting industry in Cholo and Mlanje is completely dependent on alien native labour', any attempt to block it 'will mean the closing down of all the tea estates'. He added that it was the Lomwe alone, meaning both seasonal workers and those newly arrived but domiciled in Nyasaland, who were

doing the very rough work – work which no Nyasaland labourer will do. There is plenty of Nyasaland labour for soft jobs or skilled work, but there are no Nyasaland natives, to speak about, who will do the rough work, and 75 %, or probably 80 % of the work on tea estates is represented by rough work.³³

It was noted in Cholo the following year, however, that Lomwe workers already aspired to be promoted from hoeing to the more remunerative and less onerous task of plucking.³⁴ The fifth category of tea workers were children, whose employment the Governor endorsed,³⁵ and who always comprised a significant component of the workforce. Pressures from Britain resulted in wartime legislation banning the employment of children under twelve and imposing a maximum of six hours per day of light work for those between twelve and fourteen, but the Nyasaland Government lacked the manpower to enforce such laws. In the period 1950–3 the number of youths under eighteen employed at the end of March varied from 6,435 to 9,566.³⁶ Sixth and finally, there was casual daily labour known as *ganyu*. This was generally resorted to 'when work urgently required to be done gets beyond the capacity of the normal labour force; it is often done by women'.³⁷ In the 1930s it was normally confined to such tasks as weeding, but its scope was

³¹ Federation of Rhodesia and Nyasaland, *Report of an Economic Survey of Nyasaland, 1958–1959* (Salisbury, 1960), 40.

³² Foreign and Commonwealth Office Library, East Africa Commission on Closer Union, Evidence of Mlanje Planters' Association, 25 March 1928, 182.

³³ C.O. 525/154/25403, Minutes of the 7th meeting of the Select Committee on Agricultural Development, 31 May 1934.

³⁴ S 1/79^C/36, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1935.

³⁵ The Acting Governor told the Colonial Office that 'both the Governor and myself have seen the children at work and they appear to like it. The work is simple, consisting principally of picking out defective leaves and stalks from partially manufactured tea. Were they not so employed they would doubtless be less wholesomely occupied in their insanitary villages, and the money they receive from the estates is a help to their parents'. C.O. 525/137/33418/30, Davidson-Houston to Passfield, 15 March 1930.

³⁶ *Labour Department Annual Reports, 1950–3*.

³⁷ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ended 31st December, 1949* (Zomba, 1950), 4.

greatly widened in response to the growing post-war labour shortage. On 31 March 1954, some 3,810 casual workers were employed in the Tea Industry, of whom 2,775 (73 per cent) were women, 700 (18 per cent) were juveniles and 335 (9 per cent) were men.³⁸ Thereafter the number of *ganyu* workers rose steadily each year to reach 12,038 in 1958.³⁹

WAGES AND WORKING CONDITIONS

Early in 1930, in response to enquiries from the Imperial Economic Committee, the district commissioner in Mlanje toured the local tea estates and made a number of recommendations, unwelcomed by his superiors,⁴⁰ designed to reduce the risk of fire in tea factories. He also described in detail the wage structure then operating on the estates. At that time some 9,000 acres were under tea in Nyasaland, 7,500 of them in Mlanje. By 1940 the acreage had doubled to 18,000, equally divided between Mlanje and Cholo, while by 1953 there were 23,000 acres of tea in the country. It was estimated that the industry required approximately one person per acre in the dry season, rising to one and a half per acre during the peak rainy season.⁴¹

The D.C., Mlanje, found that many different categories of workers were employed. At the bottom, hoers earned 7s. per ticket plus either food rations or 6d. per week *posho*. The working week was six days. Pluckers received a minimum of 7s. with the same food allowance. But they also received a bonus for picking more than the standard daily weight. This averaged 2s., though the best pluckers could make 4s. or even 8s. under exceptionally favourable conditions, which would bring the wage up to 15s. Plucking was however only carried out for less than half the year, during the rains. In the tea factories unskilled workers earned 7s., skilled workers 10s. A small number of skilled masons, carpenters etc. were paid 'up to' 30s. and clerks 'up to' 80s. The length of the working day varied. Hoers worked a 'task day' averaging six hours, pluckers worked ten hours and factory workers shifts of between nine and twelve hours, with factories working round the clock in the busy rush season. Child workers received between 2s. and 6s. according to age and ability, plus half rations or 3d. per week *posho*. In 1932 in Cholo 3,828 children were employed in the plucking season.⁴² To the surprise of planters with Far Eastern experience, very few women could be induced to work;⁴³

³⁸ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ended 31st December, 1954* (Zomba, 1955), 30.

³⁹ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ended 31st December, 1958* (Zomba, 1959), 42.

⁴⁰ The Provincial Commissioner for the Southern Province responded to his proposals by hoping that it would 'not be found necessary to harass the Managers of Tea Estates with a great number of rules and regulations', while the Governor was reported to be 'reluctant to put the firms to inconvenience and expense by a number of vexatious regulations': NS 1/13/1, P.C., Southern Province, to Chief Secretary, 29 Jan. 1930; *ibid.*, P.C., Southern Province, to D.C., Mlanje, 12 Feb. 1930.

⁴¹ BEA Archives, Tea Association file, Memo by Laycock, Director, Tea Research Station, Mlanje, Dec. 1964.

⁴² S 1/43^C/33, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1932.

⁴³ 'It was foreign to me', wrote 'An Itinerant Engineer', 'to see the local labour force, termed "boys" and consisting chiefly of hefty coloured gentlemen all plucking leaf, instead of women and children being employed for this work as is customary in other tea growing countries': An Itinerant Engineer, 'Notes upon a visit paid to tea estates in the Nyasaland Protectorate', *Nyasaland Tea Association Quarterly Journal*, III, 1 (1938), 6.

those who did were paid at child rates. This situation was to persist until the early 1970s.⁴⁴ Casual day labourers were paid from 4d. to 6d. as hoers, 6d. to 1s. as pluckers and 6d. to 9d. in the factories. They received neither food nor *posho*. Regular pluckers and factory workers 'on most estates' were however provided with cooked food at midday plus a daily ration of raw food, which the D.C. considered usually very good and 'well over' the official ration scale laid down by the government. The cost of food to the employer was between 1¼d. and 1½d. per man per day. 'Wages may seem small to any person not accustomed to conditions in the Protectorate', explained the D.C., 'but they are adequate for the labour; and the industry cannot afford to pay any higher wages'. Tea had to be landed in London at not more than 9d. per lb. Landed at the local railhead of Luchenza it cost 6d., of which 3d. comprised native wages: 'it is therefore obvious that any increase in wages would be a matter of great concern to managers and owners of tea estates'.⁴⁵ Tea prices were indeed depressed in 1930 and in the following year 'tea could not be marketed at a profit',⁴⁶ but the Colonial Office was 'not impressed by the argument that the industry cannot afford proper wages and conditions' and the Governor was told to use his influence to improve them.⁴⁷

Wages naturally fluctuated over time. Throughout the 1920s the basic minimum wage had tended to remain constant at 6s. per ticket plus 6d. per week *posho*. It dipped to as low as 5s. during the Depression, tending to stay there longer in Mlanje (to 1936) than in Cholo. A rise in world tea prices combined with a local shortage of labour to push the basic wage in Cholo in 1938 up to 8s., with some planters offering 9s. But the Mlanje estates were still paying only 6s. in 1941, and the 1930 wage of 7s. was not reached again until 1943. A severe post-war labour shortage coupled with the rapidly rising cost of living served to ease the minimum wage upwards, and in 1947 the industry's governing body, the Nyasaland Tea Association (NTA), prudently agreed that 'it would be best to raise it voluntarily rather than be forced to do so'.⁴⁸ In the fierce competition for labour much ill-feeling was caused within the industry when some planters 'jumped the gun' and raised wages without the Association's prior approval.⁴⁹ The minimum wage reached 12s. by 1945 and 15s. by 1948. It rose again to 17s. 6d. in August 1950, to the consternation of one leading tea-producing company,⁵⁰ while by 1953, the

⁴⁴ In 1973 the Manager of the Glenorchy Estate in Mlanje noted that 'During the past season women increased their share of the crop to approximately 2/5 of the daily intake, and they are now a vital element in the estate's plucking force': BEA Archives, Estate Reports, Glenorchy Estate, Manager's Annual Report for the year ending 30th September, 1973.

⁴⁵ NS 1/13/1, D.C., Mlanje, to P.C., Southern Province, 28 Feb. 1930.

⁴⁶ Nyasaland Protectorate, *Annual Report of the Department of Agriculture, 1931* (Zomba, 1932), 10.

⁴⁷ C.O. 525/137/33418/30, Minute by Shiels, 29 Apr. 1930; *ibid.*, Passfield to Thomas, 18 June 1930.

⁴⁸ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/5, Minutes of Meeting of the Board of Directors [henceforth MMBD], Nyasaland Tea Association [henceforth NTA], 28 Nov. 1941.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, MMBD, NTA, 5 Nov. 1948; *ibid.*, MMBD, NTA, 7 Jan. 1957.

⁵⁰ On hearing of this increase, the Edinburgh Board of Blantyre and East Africa Ltd. observed: 'We would welcome this legislation if it meant additional work from the natives but each successive increase has not brought any additional effort on the worker's part and the whole policy of wage increases without further efforts stands condemned. We shall

year of Federation and the Cholo riots, Mlanje was paying 17s. 6d. and Cholo 20s. *Posho* was then around 2s. per week. These increases had the effect of nudging wages upwards on the neighbouring tea estates in Portuguese East Africa.⁵¹

The figures cited above⁵² are all basic minimum wages and so do not convey the full complexity of the wage structure. Thus in Cholo in 1938, for example, it was claimed that the average plucker 'can easily earn' 15s. to 20s. and that 'the more active ones' earned 30s. during the limited plucking season.⁵³ In 1941, when the minimum wage stood at 6s., it was thought that the average wage on tea estates, including the 6d. per week *posho*, could be put at 10s. 5d.,⁵⁴ while on Lauderdale Estate in Mlanje the most skilled workers could earn 'up to' 40s.⁵⁵ Yet, even taking such variables into account, figures such as these certainly tend to endorse Vail's depiction of Nyasaland as 'an island of atrocious working conditions and wretched wages in a region characterized by poor working conditions and low pay'.⁵⁶ Even by the parsimonious standards of southern Africa, Nyasaland's tea wages were low, being on a par only with those offered in Portuguese East Africa. The NTA candidly admitted that this was the case but argued that the productivity of most workers was also low. Whilst Nyasa workers readily worked long hours throughout southern Africa, thereby earning a high reputation, they could not be induced to do so at home. Malcolm Barrow probably spoke for all Nyasaland's tea planters when he informed the 1938 Bledisloe Commission:

Because they are living in their own country and in their own villages they will not work continuously and their capacity for work in their own country is small. They will not work in the same way as they will when they go south, where they are dependent on the money they earn.⁵⁷

From time to time the Nyasaland Government, with occasional promptings from the Colonial Office,⁵⁸ urged the tea industry to improve both wage

have to get good prices to offset the rise in costs': BEA Archives, General letters from Edinburgh 1949-52, Stark to General Manager, Blantyre, 2 Aug. 1950.

⁵¹ Leroy Vail and Landeg White, *Capitalism and Colonialism in Mozambique* (London, 1980), 331.

⁵² The wage figures cited here were obtained from the Cholo and Mlanje annual reports, from the records of the Nyasaland Tea Association, from the Labour Department annual reports and from estate records in the Blantyre and East Africa Archives. It is clear that the wage levels cited in the published Labour Department reports were inflated.

⁵³ NSE 5/1/5, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1938.

⁵⁴ *Labour Department Annual Report, 1941*, 5.

⁵⁵ BEA Archives, Tait Bowie papers, Hadden to Tait Bowie, 26 March 1941.

⁵⁶ Vail, 'The state', 50. John McCracken categorizes the wages of the early 1930s as being 'surely among the lowest wages in the world': John McCracken, 'Peasants, planters and the colonial state: the case of Malawi, 1905-1940', *Journal of Eastern African Research and Development*, xii (1982), 31.

⁵⁷ Bledisloe Commission, Evidence of M. P. Barrow, 25 June 1938, 1035. The 1948 Labour Report bemoaned the fact that 'The incentive which will turn the African villager into a steady regular wage-earner when living in his own country has yet to be discovered'. *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ending 31st December, 1948* (Zomba, 1949), 4.

⁵⁸ In 1941 Colonial Secretary Moyne read 'with some concern' reports of the lack of interest shown by some Mlanje tea planters 'in the life and welfare of their labourers after working hours', and added that 'It is most desirable in their own interest that employers should be encouraged to do everything possible to create a contented labour force, and

levels and working conditions, suggesting that greater generosity might enhance the supply of labour. Thus in 1937, the year in which a Labour Commissioner was first appointed, the D.C., Cholo, noted that 'with one exception... the living conditions prevailing on these estates are certainly not attractive'. He acknowledged that the capital outlay required to build brick houses 'must of course be very heavy', but he deemed it a necessary expense at a time of increasingly strong competition for labour from Southern Rhodesia, which had recently inaugurated a 'free' lorry transport service for workers heading south. The Provincial Commissioner for the Southern Province commented that 'The time is coming when these thriving planters will have to spend money on accommodation if they are to attract labour when so many other sources of employment are available'.⁵⁹ This was endorsed a year later by the visiting commissioner, Sir Robert Bell, who warned planters that 'they should provide amenities, including better housing, which the emigrant frequently enjoys outside Nyasaland. Many estates can afford to do this now'.⁶⁰ The Labour Commissioner made similar comments after touring the tea estates in 1941.⁶¹ The NTA riposted that such criticisms were 'not always entirely fair'. It pointed out that during the late 1930s, as the industry's fortunes began to improve, so housing and other conditions were ameliorated, often 'very considerably'.⁶²

There is a certain amount of evidence which lends support to the Association's claims. In Cholo in 1936, in what was described as a 'highly successful' year for the industry, it was reported that

Local employers are making conditions more attractive with the object of building up for themselves the nucleus of a permanent resident labour supply. More attention has been paid to housing generally and in one instance at least model brick compounds have been built – each hut having a door with lock – at a cost of 42s. per hut. Marketplaces and other facilities are now present for workers to augment their rations without difficulty and more attention is being paid to hygiene and the supply of fuel, water etc. for the workers. Early morning tea and a cooked meal is given on some tea estates when the labour is first turned out to work and one planter has gone to the extent of providing his pluckers with mackintoshes and sou'westers.⁶³

By 1940 Cholo planters were supplementing normal rations with a weekly issue of fish and sugar in a vain attempt to persuade 'the local native... to take up a hoe',⁶⁴ while three years later the D.C., Cholo, reported that housing conditions had shown 'a distinct improvement in recent years; employers realizing that a well-housed labour force produces more satisfactory it should be possible for every employer to show, by providing inexpensive benefits such as simple recreational facilities, that he does not regard the labourer merely as a machine': BEA Archives, Tait Bowie papers, Moyne to Mackenzie-Kennedy, 26 June 1941.

⁵⁹ NSE 5/1/5, Note by P.C., Southern Province, on the Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1937.

⁶⁰ Colonial Office, *Report of the Commission Appointed to Enquire into the Financial Position and Further Development of Nyasaland*, Colonial no. 152 (London, 1938), 75.

⁶¹ BEA Archives, Tait Bowie papers, Minutes of meeting of Central Labour Advisory Board, 27 March 1941.

⁶² Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/3, Minutes of 5th Annual General Meeting [henceforth AGM], NTA, 24 Apr. 1941.

⁶³ S 1/66^C/37, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1936.

⁶⁴ NSE 5/1/7, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1940.

work'.⁶⁵ In 1944 he noted that 'With very few exceptions, all the Tea Estates have built excellent housing for their labour. The accommodation provided by Government compares very unfavourably with them'.⁶⁶ The following year he could discern that 'the quality and variety of rations issued to labour is also improving steadily'.⁶⁷ In Mlanje, where the tea estates were much longer established, relations with tenants and workers were less strained and conditions perhaps required less amelioration than in Cholo. Indeed in 1946 the Manager of the Ruw Estate went so far as to claim that 'the relations in the Mlanje District between labour and employer on Tea Estates were better than in any other part of the world'.⁶⁸ The local D.C. noted in 1943 that 'Considerable improvements have been made in housing and feeding native employees on nearly all tea estates',⁶⁹ and three years later that 'the conditions of labour are as high as can be expected'.⁷⁰ These comments of the Cholo and Mlanje district commissioners were generally endorsed in the annual reports of the Labour Department during the early 1940s.⁷¹ By 1945, after prompting from the Colonial Office, the NTA was contemplating the appointment of its own medical officer, 'who could guide the industry in the matter of diet, housing, siting of houses, etc'.⁷² Malcolm Barrow for one was convinced that 'there is no doubt that the African employee as a whole has never been better fed and cared for than he is today. As to whether he appreciates it is another matter'.⁷³ The worker's appreciation of his situation will be examined shortly.

THE 'LABOUR PROBLEM'

The 'labour problem', as perceived by the planters, varied in intensity over time and was more acutely felt in Cholo than Mlanje, which had a much longer history of plantation labour.⁷⁴ The rapid expansion of the tea estates in Cholo during the 1930s, which more than doubled labour requirements within a few years, combined with the 'irritability' of a number of local planters and tighter border restrictions by the Portuguese authorities to produce a situation by 1938 in which labour was 'becoming increasingly difficult to obtain'.⁷⁵ Barrow grew concerned that planting activities would soon be

⁶⁵ *Ibid.*, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1943.

⁶⁶ NSE 5/1/8, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1944.

⁶⁷ *Ibid.*, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1945.

⁶⁸ Foreign and Commonwealth Office Library, Land Commission 1946, Volume 2, Evidence of E. Snell, 31 July 1946, 153. [Henceforth Land Commission, Evidence.] The fact that Mlanje escaped the troubles of the early 1950s might be cited as supporting evidence for this contention.

⁶⁹ NSM 3/1/8, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1943.

⁷⁰ NSM 3/1/8, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1946.

⁷¹ *Annual Report of the Labour Department of the Provincial Administration for the Year Ending 31st December, 1940* (Zomba, 1941), 2; *Labour Department Annual Report, 1941*, 4; *Labour Department Annual Report, 1944*, 2.

⁷² Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/5, MMBD, NTA, 29 Aug. 1945.

⁷³ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/4, Minutes of 9th AGM, NTA, 17 Apr. 1945.

⁷⁴ As early as 1904 there were 11,470 people working on the six estates then established in Mlanje: Mlanje District Book, 1904-7.

⁷⁵ NSE 5/1/5, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1938. The D.C. conceded that some of the planters might be described as 'irritable', adding that all planters were short of labour, 'the irritable ones more so'.

'endangered', noting that 'many of the older planters who had not previously been inconvenienced were now having difficulty in maintaining a full labour force'.⁷⁶ It was from this time that Cholo planters began looking to the Central Province for an answer to their problem.⁷⁷ Some temporary relief was soon provided by the government however. Even before the Japanese capture of the Dutch East Indian tea fields, tea production in wartime Nyasaland was accorded a new priority.⁷⁸ By April 1941 Barrow observed a 'noticeable increase' in the amount of local labour turning out, more than he could ever recall since his arrival in the country in 1927. This he attributed to 'the straightforward way in which His Excellency the Governor has pointed out to our native population the necessity of increasing their output of work in every direction towards honest war effort'.⁷⁹ The Labour Department confirmed that there was 'a general understanding that idlers will not be tolerated in the villages'.⁸⁰ Such 'persuasion' was repeated in 1942, but the NTA believed that still more should be done. Barrow told the Association's seventh annual general meeting that while 'most of us are satisfied that compulsory labour is undesirable', nevertheless government should seek by propaganda

to make those who are sitting idly in the villages, while their friends and relations are pulling their weight in the armed forces, see that it is their duty to the community to work for the common benefit in the production of the crops that are necessary at the present time.⁸¹

In the event the government declined to sanction overt compulsory labour for the estates, in contrast to the situation in Northern Rhodesia, Tanganyika and Kenya.

After the war, partly as a response to wartime government pressures and partly because of rapidly expanding employment opportunities both at home and abroad, the 'labour shortage' on the tea estates became progressively more acute. As noted earlier, the problem was first severely felt in Cholo in 1938, when 'some thousands of lbs of tea' went unplucked,⁸² but by 1946–8 the figure was between one and two million pounds, with an estimated 2,000 acres out of production in 1947.⁸³ In 1952 Barrow lamented that 'the tea industry since 1949 had experienced an acute shortage of labour', resulting

⁷⁶ S 1/96/37, Record of a discussion...on emigrant labour, 15 Nov. 1938.

⁷⁷ They had tried earlier, in 1934, but the results had proved 'most disappointing'. Only 100 of 201 recruited in South Nyasa actually started work, 'the remainder either deserted or failed to reach their destination. No volunteers were forthcoming from the Upper Shire District and very few from Chiradzulu': *Annual Reports of the Provincial Commissioners for the Year Ended 31st December, 1934* (Zomba, 1935), 15.

⁷⁸ The official order of priorities was stated to be: (1) to keep the East African Army up to strength; (2) to concentrate on foodstuffs for local use and for neighbours; (3) to assist the production of economic crops; (4) to assist local planters, Southern Rhodesia and the Rand in the matter of labour: C.O. 525/189/44053/23, Nyasaland Government, Circular No. 15, 20 March 1942, citing a 1940 circular.

⁷⁹ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/3, Minutes of 5th AGM, NTA, 24 Apr. 1941.

⁸⁰ *Labour Department Annual Report, 1941*, 2.

⁸¹ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/3, Minutes of 5th AGM, NTA, 24 Apr. 1941.

⁸² NSE 5/1/5, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1938.

⁸³ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/4, Minutes of Special General Meeting, NTA, 7 Jan. 1947; *ibid.*, Minutes of the 12th AGM, NTA, 16 June 1948.

in the loss of 'some 2 to 3 million pounds of tea a year'.⁸⁴ The Department of Agriculture's annual report for 1951 commented that 'The future prosperity of Nyasaland's tea industry appears to be more dependent on the solving of this labour problem than on any other factor'.⁸⁵ The government was sufficiently alarmed by the loss of revenue – it had imposed an unpopular export tax of 2*d.* per lb on tea and tobacco in 1949 – and by the great famine of the same year⁸⁶ to propose that the tea industry make arrangements to grow its own food requirements and not rely, as it had done hitherto, on peasant production. In 1950 Chikomwe Farms was formed with the task of producing food on estates near Zomba specifically to feed plantation workers.⁸⁷ It was hoped that such workers would thus be 'spared' the need to work in their own fields and would thus have more time to devote themselves to the thousands of acres of unplucked tea. The scheme proved a failure however, and at a meeting of the NTA's Board of Directors in 1957, 'the consensus of opinion was that there was always a shortage of labour in the Industry'.⁸⁸

One interesting response to this crisis was a redivision of labour on the Blantyre and East Africa tea estates, described by the company's General Manager in July 1954. He noted that because

we cannot depend upon a full plucking force any longer during December, January and February... all regular adult labour... which can be spared from manufacture, planting out new extensions, renovation and reafforestation programmes, is put on plucking whether they like it or not, and this plucking force has very often had to be supplemented with gangs of women paid at daily rates, especially during the last four years.

However, he went on to suggest that this offered no real solution, since plucking, 'despite the attraction of bonus', was unpopular because of the long hours worked in the rain, and 'When the time comes that all labour is required for plucking, absenteeism increases tremendously and [only] a hard core of diehards remains'.⁸⁹ The labour shortage on the estates was in fact to persist for a further two decades before being remedied by the virtual sealing off of alternative options within the southern African economic region.

WORKER RESPONSES

There are sharply conflicting views concerning the plight of workers on Nyasaland's tea estates during this period. Sir Sidney Abrahams, whose 1946 Land Commission collected much evidence in the Shire Highlands, concluded that people living on the estates felt that 'they were mere slaves',⁹⁰ a view subsequently endorsed by Vail, for whom the Lomwe 'had become the

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*, Minutes of Extraordinary General Meeting, NTA, 6 Feb. 1952.

⁸⁵ *Report of the Department of Agriculture for the Year 1951* (Zomba, 1952), 8.

⁸⁶ Megan Vaughan, 'Famine analysis and family relations: 1949 in Nyasaland', *Past and Present*, CVIII (1985), 177–205.

⁸⁷ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/4, Minutes of 14th AGM, NTA, 10 Aug. 1950; BEA Archives, Tea Association file 1949–51.

⁸⁸ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/5, MMBD, NTA, 17 Apr. 1957.

⁸⁹ BEA Archives, Estate Reports, Acting General Manager, Blantyre, General Report No. 5, June–July 1954.

⁹⁰ Nyasaland Protectorate, *Land Commission 1946*, Volume 1, *Report by the Rt. Hon. Sir Sidney Abrahams, P.C.* (Zomba, 1946), 17. [Henceforth *Land Commission Report*.]

akapolo ("domestic slaves") of the planters',⁹¹ powerless to combat the built-in sanctions of the *thangata* system. Tea planters (and other landowners) naturally saw things in a rather different light. They believed that the increasing assertiveness of tenants had made *thangata* virtually unenforceable by 1946 and that contracts constrained the employer far more than the worker, who could ignore them with impunity. The Manager of the British Central Africa Company, which admittedly had a deplorable record in labour relations, complained to Abrahams that 'Estate Owners suffered many disadvantages'⁹² and this was certainly also the view of the Blantyre and East Africa management.

If workers did indeed perceive themselves to be 'mere slaves', there is evidence to suggest that they were far from passive slaves, for there are many recorded cases of 'loafing', absenteeism, 'desertion', non-cooperation and malicious retaliation; of tenants consciously taking their time to fulfil legal obligations; and of acute market awareness of the comparative disadvantage of working on the tea estates. In short, we find manifestations of the kinds of hidden local, day-to-day and passive resistance appropriate to the conditions of American slave plantations, Southern Rhodesian mining compounds – and Nyasaland tea estates. As early as 1938, for example, it was reported from Cholo that

The natives fully realise their value and have undoubtedly got the planter in the palm of their hands. They will make and sign any agreement without having the slightest intention of carrying it out. They give wrong names and villages to their employers in the majority of cases, in consequence it is almost impossible to trace deserters. It is also quite clear that the planter cannot even suggest that his labour is not performing a day's work without having trouble.

Four of them have at different times informed me that they do not rigidly enforce orders for fear of malicious retaliation. During the last few years there have been several very unpleasant incidents.

Women refuse to work in any capacity.⁹³

The 'incidents' involved 'wilful damage to crops and buildings'.⁹⁴

Some employers literally had to restrain themselves. In 1932 Mlanje planters were unwilling to take 'deserters' to law 'from fear of acquiring a bad name',⁹⁵ while in Cholo in 1937 the fear was of 'the labour moving off to some planter who is more lenient'. Cholo planters were so desperate to keep tenants on their estates that 'the native realises this and he is definitely taking advantage of it'. Moreover, planters could not agree wage rates among themselves 'and in consequence they are continually bringing in new forms of inducement to attract labour from each other'.⁹⁶ Cholo planters went out on recruiting campaigns and brought some workers back, but 'after enjoying the lorry rides to the estates and after sampling the food the estates provided for about a week or so they slowly disappeared and walked back home'.⁹⁷ An

⁹¹ Vail, 'The state', 50–1.

⁹² Land Commission, Evidence of J. Kaye-Nicol, 13 Aug. 1946, 56.

⁹³ NSE 5/1/5, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1938.

⁹⁴ *Annual Reports of the Provincial Commissioners for the Year Ended 31st December, 1938* (Zomba, 1939), 17.

⁹⁵ S 1/43^E/33, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1932.

⁹⁶ NSE 5/1/5, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1937.

⁹⁷ Lindeirey, 'The tea industry', 18.

increasing response from tea planters, already irritated at being unable to enforce the length of working day demanded on Southern Rhodesian farms, was reluctantly to lessen the daily task demanded. Thus the D.C., Mlanje, lamented in 1932 that 'the average native seems incapable of doing what was considered an ordinary day's work twenty years ago',⁹⁸ while by 1946 the daily task had been reduced to such an extent that 'the older employers reckon that it is a bare half of what used to be accomplished twenty years ago'.⁹⁹ Similarly, and this was quite infuriating to the many planters with Far Eastern experience, it was stated in 1940 that 'Thousands of pounds of leaf are lost every year through local labour refusing to turn out because it is wet or just threatening to rain',¹⁰⁰ a state of affairs the planter Arthur Westrop noted caustically, 'difficult to imagine in Ceylon or India'.¹⁰¹ By 1948 Mlanje labour had become so 'soft' that there had been difficulties regarding work on Sundays;¹⁰² Barrow lamented that 'the time was approaching when the African would also refuse to work on Bank Holidays'.¹⁰³ By 1944 absenteeism in Mlanje had 'increased considerably'.¹⁰⁴ It was most prevalent, the D.C. noted the following year, 'amongst the class of labour who lives at home', but it was also on the increase in estate compounds, where

Various methods to combat this have been tried by employers such as offering a bonus for regular attendance at work, but none have been effective and the African continues to turn up for work when he feels inclined.¹⁰⁵

In Cholo in 1946 many workers absented themselves 'habitually, without reason' and took two or three months to complete their thirty day tickets.¹⁰⁶ In 1948 it was noted generally that planters never brought actions for breach of contract as they were 'reluctant to do anything which might make them unpopular with their African labour'.¹⁰⁷

Problems such as these were exacerbated, from the planter's point of view, by the difficulty of effectively supervising the large number of workers needed on a tea estate. In Southern Rhodesia a labour force of sixty on a tobacco farm was considered large, whereas on a Nyasaland tea estate 'one European might be in charge of 300 to 400 men, as well as women and youngsters'.¹⁰⁸ Moreover, the variety of tasks to be performed in any one day was so varied that

⁹⁸ S 1/43^E/33, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1932.

⁹⁹ *Annual Report of the Labour Department for the Year Ending 31st December, 1946* (Zomba, 1947), 4. In the years 1941-4 'the pruning task...has been reduced, to take one example, from 85 bushes per day to 55 bushes. Employers have found that the reduction has been forced upon them by the apparent inability of the labour to finish a larger task and the risk of losing their men altogether if they are pressed': *Labour Department Annual Report, 1944*, 2.

¹⁰⁰ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/2, Minutes of 4th AGM, NTA, 2 Apr. 1940.

¹⁰¹ A 3/2/246, A. R. Westrop, 'Report on tea in Nyasaland', 12 March 1934.

¹⁰² A hundred workers at the Lauderdale tea factory refused to work overtime on Sundays unless the rate of 1s. per 8½ hours was doubled. The management refused this demand, preferring not to work the factory on Sundays. NS 3/1/17, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1948; *Labour Department Annual Report 1948*, 16.

¹⁰³ Hist. MSS. NY 11/1/5, MMBD, NTA, 14 Jan. 1949.

¹⁰⁴ NSM 3/1/8, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1944.

¹⁰⁵ *Ibid.*, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1945.

¹⁰⁶ NSE 5/1/8, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1946.

¹⁰⁷ *Labour Department Annual Report, 1948*, 4.

¹⁰⁸ Arthur Westrop, *Green Gold* (Bulawayo, c. 1964), 216.

any attempts to personally overlook every gang at work would be doomed to failure. Hence much of the control has to be deputed to the Capitaos, many of whom do not compare in efficiency with their opposite numbers in India or Ceylon.¹⁰⁹

This lack of tight supervision may have been some minimal compensation for the low wages received.

Addressing himself to the 'labour problem' in his annual report for 1944, the D.C., Mlanje, observed

The fact is that the wage paid for unskilled labour is not sufficient to ensure regular attendance at work in a district where other opportunities for earning money are available i.e. production and sale of foodstuff and tobacco, trading, and brewing of beer, to name a few; many families live on the regular remittances sent by relatives serving in the Forces, add to these facts a good harvest and there is little inducement to work regularly for a monthly rate which will not buy a tax or a decent cloth in these days.¹¹⁰

Contemplating the same problem in 1946, the D.C., Cholo, reached similar conclusions. His explanations for the 'labour shortage' included

a lack of consumer goods coupled with inordinate amounts of money lying idle in the possession of the native population; together with a growing conviction in the minds of young men to-day that of all the forms of obtaining money manual labour in Nyasaland offers the most unattractive form of work, for the least money, and with the worst prospects of advancement. In pursuance of this conviction large numbers of these young men are trying either to get specialized and better-paid jobs, or to grow produce commanding high prices, or to better themselves by emigrating; anything in fact rather than work locally as paid labourers.¹¹¹

POST-WAR STRIKES AND DISTURBANCES IN CHOLO

At the end of the Second World War many parts of Africa were seething with unrest in both town and countryside. The Cholo district of southern Nyasaland, with a population density approaching 200 per square mile,¹¹² was no exception. Some grievances there related specifically to conditions and wages on the tea estates, others to the wider land question and the enforcement of new agricultural rules, while others again were basically political in origin. Relations between landlord and tenant were particularly strained on the estates of the British Central Africa (BCA) Company in northern Cholo. Here the company owned the Chisunga and Mindali tea estates and over 100,000 acres in the district in all.¹¹³ It had a long history of 'unsympathetic

¹⁰⁹ *Ibid.*, 246.

¹¹⁰ NSM 3/1/8, Report of the D.C., Mlanje, for 1944.

¹¹¹ NSE 5/1/8, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1946.

¹¹² The population of Cholo (624 square miles) rose from 59,154 in 1931 to 119,746 in 1945, the population density thus rising from 94.8 to 191.9 per square mile. The comparable figures for Mlanje (1,511 square miles) were: population rising from 134,431 to 209,522 and density from 87.8 to 138.7 per square mile. In 1945 there were 74,465 Africans (38,066 men and 36,399 women) living on private estates in Cholo, compared to only 16,207 (8,717 men and 7,490 women) in Mlanje. The total number living on private estates in the whole country was 211,394. *Land Commission Report*, 4; Central African Statistical Office, *Statistical Handbook of Nyasaland, 1952* (Salisbury, 1952), 14.

¹¹³ In 1948 the British Central Africa Company owned 329,353 acres in Nyasaland, 103,957 of them in Cholo. In 1949 it agreed to sell 182,493 acres to the government at 12s. 6d. per acre. C.O. 525/208/44332/3, 'History of the British Central Africa Company', 15; C.O. 1015/773, Minute by Nield, 20 July 1953.

and aggressive' management and the Government Lands Officer warned prophetically in 1948 that it employed white managers 'who are known to have a provocative and demoralising influence on their labour', and whose conduct 'gives rise to numerous incidents, any one of which might prove the occasion for serious political trouble'.¹¹⁴

There were indeed many incidents in Cholo, on the BCA estates and elsewhere, in the immediate post-war years.¹¹⁵ In 1945 many BCA tenants together with tenants on another estate refused to pay rent. Some challenged the right of the companies to charge rent at all, others were protesting at the recent reduction in the size of tenant gardens and the refusal to grant gardens to their children. The two companies threatened 1,250 tenants with eviction but the government, with no land available on which to resettle such numbers, eventually persuaded them to evict only 120. It was subsequently reported that whilst little bitterness was expressed, 'it was obvious that it was felt'.¹¹⁶

In 1946, the year in which the Land Commission took evidence, an event which in itself aroused new expectations, there was a strike at a Cholo tea factory which attempted to secure 'improved conditions'.¹¹⁷ In 1947 two hundred drivers and factory workers at Conforzi's Mboma Estate struck over a change in the system of payment. No agreement could be reached and all were paid off, though it was reported that 90 per cent subsequently re-engaged.¹¹⁸ In 1949 thirty of Conforzi's drivers demanded a pay increase and threatened to strike again, but a Labour Adviser intervened and prevented a stoppage.¹¹⁹ In 1949 and again in 1950 the BCA Company encountered 'considerable difficulty' in collecting rents. It evicted 'a considerable number' of tenants in 1950, who 'were persuaded to leave voluntarily, no force being employed. But these evictions left behind them a deep sense of grievance'.¹²⁰

Matters came to a head in 1952-3. The collapse in tea prices following the reopening of the London Auctions placed the BCA Company in 'considerable financial embarrassment'.¹²¹ Its General Manager in Nyasaland, A. C. Dixon, determined to turn the screw on his tenants. The 1952 Africans on Private Estates Ordinance had raised the maximum permissible rent from 20s. to 52s. 6d., and though other companies agreed not to push for this and it was not in any event legally enforceable until July 1953, Dixon issued a circular,

¹¹⁴ C.O. 525/208/44332/3, 'History of the British Central Africa Company', 19.

¹¹⁵ There were also earlier incidents on the Blantyre and East Africa's Limbali Estate, Mlanje in 1942, in which the estate's General Manager was severely censured for his behaviour towards tenants, and in 1943 in Blantyre, when 'several hundreds' refused to obey eviction orders. BEA Archives, Labour disputes Limbali file 1942-3, Tait Bowie to Dunn, 17 Jan. 1942; *ibid.*, Tait Bowie to Stark, 7 Feb. 1942; *Land Commission Report*, 14.

¹¹⁶ C.O. 1015/773, 'Report by H. V. McDonald, Land Settlement Officer, on unrest on estates in the Cholo District', Aug. 1953 [henceforth 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates']; *Land Commission Report*, 15.

¹¹⁷ NSE 5/1/8, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1946.

¹¹⁸ NS 3/1/15, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1947; *Annual Report of the Provincial Commissioners. Native Administration 1947* (Zomba, 1948), 5.

¹¹⁹ NS 3/1/15, Report of the D.C., Cholo, for 1949; *Labour Department Annual Report, 1949*, 21.

¹²⁰ C.O. 1015/773, 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates'.

¹²¹ *Ibid.*, Colby to Lyttelton, 9 July 1953.

described in the Colonial Office as a 'deplorable document',¹²² to his tenants in December 1952, in the rainy season, demanding the 52s. 6d. rent immediately. The government was not amused, for this was just at the time when the Nyasaland African Congress was organizing opposition to the proposed Federation of Rhodesia and Nyasaland. In the event a 'hard core' of tenants resisted Dixon's demands. He in turn demanded their expulsion and the government, though extremely reluctant to initiate action 'of a potentially dangerous nature', was obliged to confirm the eviction notices. Tensions continued to mount during the early months of 1953 'until finally it became clear, even to the General Manager, that execution of the eviction notices on which he had insisted would only create civil disturbances without any prospect of it having the disciplinary effects he desired'.¹²³ In June Dixon capitulated and completely changed tack, urging that the Company should never again demand rent from its tenants. Although Governor Colby supported this, the Colonial Office felt that there were political dangers in allowing Africans to win such an 'outstanding concession' in this manner, and that it would scarcely be fair on other landowners with better labour records.¹²⁴ In fact the BCA Company's London Board agreed to a compromise solution of no evictions combined with 'no particular effort to collect rent' and refused to endorse Dixon's more radical proposal.¹²⁵ But while the correspondence was accumulating in London and Zomba, the BCA tenants had already drawn their own conclusions and in July began moving onto undeveloped parts of the company's estates and cutting trees and cultivating in order 'to demonstrate that these lands belonged to them'.¹²⁶ Their example was followed on two other tea estates. Unruly crowds began to gather and the police made six arrests.¹²⁷ Whilst this was happening it was noted that taxes were coming in slowly and that people were refusing to pay various fees or attend native courts.¹²⁸ This was the tense background to the Cholo riots which broke out on 18 August 1953.

The riots were sparked off by a trivial incident of orange stealing. Rumours spread that the thieves had been caught, killed and eaten by whites. A large crowd gathered the next morning; police read the riot act and then accidentally opened fire, shooting one man who subsequently died in hospital. A month of sporadic violence followed, spreading out from Cholo to other districts in the Shire Highlands (though not including Mlanje) and the Lower Shire.¹²⁹ Police reinforcements were sent from the Rhodesias and Tanganyika together with three reconnaissance planes from the Southern Rhodesian Air Force. The final official casualty figures were eleven dead and seventy-two injured. The tea estates were particularly badly affected. As black workers stayed away from work, intimidated, it was said, by 'agitators who were going round the estates', some white women and children were evacuated to the safety of

¹²² *Ibid.*, Minute by Nield, 26 March 1953.

¹²³ *Ibid.*, 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates'.

¹²⁴ *Ibid.*, Minute by Reed, 15 June 1953.

¹²⁵ *Ibid.*, Minute by Marnham, 17 June 1953.

¹²⁶ *Ibid.*, 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates'.

¹²⁷ *Ibid.*, Colby to Lyttelton, 10 Aug. 1953.

¹²⁸ Nyasaland Protectorate, *Report of a Commission of Inquiry Appointed by the Governor on the 20th August, 1953, under the Commissions of Inquiry Ordinance* (Zomba, 1953), 3.

¹²⁹ *Report of Commission of the 20th August, 1953*, 3-6. The districts involved were Cholo, Blantyre, Chikwawa, Port Herald, Zomba and Domasi.

Blantyre and most *chitando* labour retired prudently to Portuguese East Africa. There was much vandalism. Tea bushes were uprooted on some estates and 'a gang armed with spears, knives and staves caused extensive damage on Makwasa estate to the factory and to the manager's house, where they broke windows and threw some furniture off the verandah'.¹³⁰ As the disturbances spread over six districts, 'Native Administration in large parts of these Districts virtually ceased, in some cases Native Authority buildings were destroyed and the lawful Native Authorities were "deposed" by rioters'.¹³¹

Whether such activities, which seemed to challenge the very legitimacy of the colonial state, alarmed the government more than the Nyasaland African Congress is a moot point. Roger Tangri believes that 'The Cholo type of rural radicalism was anathema to the central body of Congress. Indeed, the disorders may well have frightened the central leadership'.¹³² At all events, under severe pressure from government, Congress called off its policy of non-cooperation in mid-September.

There has been, then and now,¹³³ something of a conspiracy of silence surrounding the Cholo riots. The Governor of Nyasaland, Sir Geoffrey Colby, appointed a local commission of inquiry, which took the view that the causes of the riots did not come within its terms of reference and which devoted itself to only the first three days of the disturbances.¹³⁴ The Colonial Office was hoodwinked by Colby's 'passion for opportunism'¹³⁵ into believing that a more substantive inquiry had taken place. When it found that this was not the case and that the commission had taken a 'surprisingly narrow view' of its terms of reference,¹³⁶ it nevertheless reluctantly felt obliged to resist the many demands to send out a British commission when Colby argued that this might 'once again...bring into question the authority of the Government',¹³⁷ or 'develop into a post mortem on federation which would do untold harm'.¹³⁸

Called to account by Whitehall, the Nyasaland Government put the blame for the disturbances on weak administration in the Lomwe areas,¹³⁹ on years of cumulative resentment at large tracts of white-owned land lying idle,¹⁴⁰

¹³⁰ C.O. 1015/773, 'Disturbances in the Cholo District, August 1953, Narrative of Events'; C.O. 1015/461, Poole to Lloyd, 28 Aug. 1953; Westrop, *Green Gold*, 341-64; Roger Tangri, 'From the politics of union to mass nationalism: the Nyasaland African Congress, 1944-59', in Macdonald (ed.), *From Nyasaland to Malawi*, 264-7; Boeder, *Silent majority*, 75-9; Robert I. Rotberg, *The rise of nationalism in Central Africa* (Cambridge, Mass., 1967), 259-62.

¹³¹ *Annual Report of the Provincial Commissioners. Native Administration 1953* (Zomba, 1954), 3.

¹³² Tangri, 'Politics of union', 273.

¹³³ The main file on the Cholo riots has been retained by the Foreign and Commonwealth Office though the subsidiary files, C.O. 1015/458-462 and 470-474, are all available at the Public Record Office.

¹³⁴ *Report of Commission of the 20th August, 1953*, 3.

¹³⁵ C.O. 1015/470, Minute by Marnham, 23 Oct. 1953.

¹³⁶ C.O. 1015/473, Minute by Marnham, 28 Nov. 1953.

¹³⁷ C.O. 1015/470, Colby to Gorell Barnes, 22 Sept. 1953. For the various demands to send out a British commission, see the files C.O. 1015/458, 459, 470-474.

¹³⁸ C.O. 1015/470, Colby to Lyttelton, 19 Oct. 1953.

¹³⁹ C.O. 1015/470, Colby to Lyttelton, 19 Oct. 1953; C.O. 1015/773, 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates'.

¹⁴⁰ C.O. 1015/773, Colby to Lyttelton, 2 Sept. 1953.

on the insecurity of tenants frequently threatened with eviction,¹⁴¹ and on 'the gradual resumption of close administration...after the laxity born of war-time administrative weakness'.¹⁴² There is little doubt too that widespread opposition to Federation throughout Nyasaland served to fan the flames of disaffection. 'Nevertheless', the Colonial Office believed, 'the land question has clearly played the major part in the troubles and has obviously got to be tackled.'¹⁴³

In the period between the 1946 Land Commission and November 1953, the Nyasaland Government had already bought from landowners some 321,000 acres at a cost of c. £188,000.¹⁴⁴ The Cholo riots gave additional urgency to this process which sought, in Abrahams' phrase, to 'emancipate' the tenants and thus defuse tensions. Colby urged that another 300,000 acres (including BCA Company land) be acquired for £200,000. He was 'anxious to drive a wedge between the bulk of the estate owners and the comparatively few owners of large areas'¹⁴⁵ and favoured punitive taxation of undeveloped land.¹⁴⁶ The Colonial Office thought this 'politically undesirable',¹⁴⁷ since it 'would bring a storm of protest from Government back benchers'¹⁴⁸ and was in any event unlikely to be effective. It preferred to take powers for compulsory acquisition, and this was in fact done in 1954. There was controversy about where the money was to come from, with the Colonial Office, though 'reluctant either to leave the problem unresolved or to have a first-class row with yet another lot of Europeans for want of £200,000',¹⁴⁹ pressing that 'Nyasaland should find the money'.¹⁵⁰ It did however begin to put pressure on the BCA Company's London Board. Colby noted that the advent of Federation coupled with government success in quelling the disturbances had resulted in a hardening of landlord attitudes,¹⁵¹ but by the end of December 1953 he felt optimistic that he would soon be able to reach a settlement with the majority of the large landowners. 'However', he warned, 'indications are that Africans will get more and more impatient, and we must clearly do something soon.'¹⁵²

¹⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 'Report on unrest on Cholo estates'.

¹⁴² C.O. 1015/707, Minute by Marnham, 14 Oct. 1953. This involved the imposition of soil conservation and other measures which had the effect of making the Native Authorities extremely unpopular. As McCracken has recently written, 'government intervention into peasant production took place in Nyasaland with an energy and conviction surpassed only in Kenya among British African colonies': John McCracken, 'Introduction', in Centre of African Studies, University of Edinburgh, *Malawi: An Alternative Pattern of Development* (Edinburgh, 1985), xiii.

¹⁴³ 'Unfortunately, it is a problem as intractable as it is of long standing. It has baffled generations of Governors and Secretaries of State since the beginning of the century': C.O. 1015/707, Minute by Marnham, 14 Oct. 1953.

¹⁴⁴ *Ibid.*, Colby to Lyttelton, 23 Nov. 1953. This left some 887,000 acres remaining in private ownership, of which 100,000 acres were under cultivation and a further 200,000 acres were either forest land or incapable of economic development. Of the remaining 587,000 acres it was deemed practicable to acquire only about 300,000 acres in large blocks.

¹⁴⁵ C.O. 1015/707, Colby to Gorell Barnes, 20 Nov. 1953.

¹⁴⁶ *Ibid.*, Colby to Gorell Barnes, 2 Oct. 1953.

¹⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, Gorell Barnes to Colby, 24 Oct. 1953.

¹⁴⁸ *Ibid.*, Minute by Williams, 27 Nov. 1953.

¹⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, Minute by Marnham, 27 Nov. 1953.

¹⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, Minute by Marnham, 12 Dec. 1953.

¹⁵¹ *Ibid.*, Colby to Gorell Barnes, 2 Oct. and 20 Nov. 1953.

¹⁵² *Ibid.*, Colby to Gorell Barnes, 22 Dec. 1953.

This attack on the owners of large tracts of undeveloped land, which continued through the 1950s,¹⁵³ was generally welcomed by the more progressive tea planters, whose own land holdings were not excessive and whose ability to expand tea acreages had in any event been constrained until 1948 by the workings of the International Tea Regulation Scheme. They welcomed it because it seemed the main hope of extinguishing 'rural radicalism' and thus of buying time, which was a rare and precious commodity in the highly politicized atmosphere of Nyasaland in the 1950s.

SUMMARY

The tea industry of southern Nyasaland employed intermittently a heterogeneous labour force of some twenty to thirty thousand and paid workers minimum wages of 7s. in 1930, rising to between 17s. 6d. and 20s. in 1953. A complex wage structure offered different rates to hoers, pluckers, factory workers and clerks. Thousands of children, but virtually no women, were employed. Wages and working conditions were acknowledged to be unattractive, even by the industry itself, and compared favourably only with those offered in Portuguese East Africa. The initial viability of the plantation sector in the Shire Highlands was made possible by the immigration of hundreds of thousands of Lomwe from Portuguese East Africa. Lomwe workers, who sought assimilation and upward mobility, have been depicted as virtual slaves of the planters, but there is evidence of effective local, day-to-day and passive resistance on their part which left planters feeling impotent, unable to turn labour out on Sundays or in the rains or enforce unpopular *thangata* (labour rent) agreements, and obliged to reduce the daily tasks demanded of the worker. Confronted with an increasingly severe shortage of labour, which caused millions of pounds of tea to remain unpicked, planters began to improve working conditions on their estates, but this failed to resolve their labour problem or to dampen post-war militancy. Irresponsible actions by the British Central Africa Company increased tensions in Cholo which culminated in the serious riots of 1953 in which eleven people were killed. Government responded to this growing rural radicalism by repurchasing half of the million acres of freehold estate land which had initially been 'bought' from chiefs prior to the colonial occupation.

¹⁵³ By May 1956 the amount of land bought by the government since 1946 had risen to 461,474 acres, and by the end of 1958 to 526,000 acres. Pachai, *Land and politics*, 144; *Report of an Economic Survey of Nyasaland*, 40.